1 Corinthians 11:17–34

Sermon Preparation Brief

River Lake Church

Prepared for Nic

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CATEGORY 1 — SCRIPTURAL INTERPRETATION: What the Text Meant

Section 1 — Passage Overview

Full Passage Text — NIV

1 Corinthians 11:17–34 falls at the heart of Paul's lengthy correction of the Corinthian church on matters of corporate worship (chapters 11–14). The passage is a rebuke: Paul opens with 'I have no praise for you' (v. 17) and closes with practical correctives (vv. 33–34). The genre is epistolary argument — pastoral correction embedded in reasoned theological appeal.

17 In the following directives I have no praise for you, for your meetings do more harm than good.

18 In the first place, I hear that when you come together as a church, there are divisions among you, and to some extent I believe it.

19 No doubt there have to be differences among you to show which of you have God's approval.

20 So then, when you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper you eat,

21 for when you are eating, some of you go ahead with your own private suppers. As a result, one person remains hungry and another gets drunk.

22 Don't you have homes to eat and drink in? Or do you despise the church of God by humiliating those who have nothing? What shall I say to you? Shall I praise you? Certainly not in this matter!

23 For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you: The Lord Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, took bread,

24 and when he had given thanks, he broke it and said, "This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me."

25 In the same way, after supper he took the cup, saying, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me."

26 For whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.

27 So then, whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of sinning against the body and blood of the Lord.

28 Everyone ought to examine themselves before they eat of the bread and drink from the cup.

29 For those who eat and drink without discerning the body of Christ eat and drink judgment on themselves.

30 That is why many among you are weak and sick, and a number of you have fallen asleep.

31 But if we were more discerning with regard to ourselves, we would not come under such judgment.

32 Nevertheless, when we are judged in this way by the Lord, we are being disciplined so that we will not be finally condemned with the world.

33 So then, my brothers and sisters, when you gather to eat, you should all wait for each other.

34 If anyone is hungry, he should eat something at home, so that when you meet together it may not result in judgment. And when I come I will give further directions.

Translation Comparison — Verse 20 (The Pivotal Accusation)

Version	v. 20 — 'It is not the Lord's Supper you eat'
NIV	So then, when you come together, it is not the Lord's Supper you eat
ESV	When you come together, it is not the Lord's supper that you eat
NLT	When you come together as a church, I hear that there are divisions among you
NASB	Therefore when you come together, it is not to eat the Lord's Supper
MSG	And when you come together, it is not really to eat the Lord's Supper

Translation Comparison — Verses 23–26 (Institution Narrative)

Version	v. 24 — 'This is my body, which is for you'
NIV	This is my body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of me.
ESV	This is my body, which is for you. Do this in remembrance of me.
NLT	This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.
NASB	This is My body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of Me.
MSG	This is my body, given for you. Eat it in my memory.

Version	v. 25 — 'The new covenant in my blood'
NIV	This cup is the new covenant in my blood; do this, whenever you drink it, in remembrance of me.
ESV	This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of me.
NLT	This cup is the new covenant between God and his people — an agreement confirmed with my blood.
NASB	This cup is the new covenant in My blood; do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me.

Translation Comparison — Verse 29 (The Contested Warning)

Version	v. 29 — 'Discerning the body'
NIV	For those who eat and drink without discerning the body of Christ eat and drink judgment on themselves.
ESV	For anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment on himself.

NLT	For if you eat the bread or drink the cup without honoring the body of Christ, you are eating and drinking God's judgment upon yourself.
NASB	For the one who eats and drinks, eats and drinks judgment to himself if he does not properly recognize the body.
MSG	If you give no thought (or worse, don't care) about the broken body of the Master when you eat and drink, you're running the risk of serious misunderstanding.

Key translational note: The ESV and NASB omit 'of Christ' after 'body' — a significant choice. The word sōma ('body') in v. 29 is left ambiguous in the Greek, opening the interpretive debate between the eucharistic body (bread) and the ecclesial body (the church). The NLT resolves the ambiguity toward the eucharistic reading; modern scholarship tends toward the ecclesial reading.

Structural Orientation

1 Corinthians is a crisis letter, written ~53 AD from Ephesus during Paul's third missionary journey. The letter responds to both oral reports (from Chloe's household, 1:11) and a written inquiry from the Corinthians. Chapters 11–14 form a coherent unit on 'gathered worship,' each section introduced by the phrase 'when you come together.' The passage's structure is:

- vv. 17–22 — The Problem: Social divisions are destroying the meal
- vv. 23–26 — The Foundation: The tradition Paul received from the Lord
- vv. 27–32 — The Warning: Unworthy participation invites divine discipline
- vv. 33–34 — The Correction: Wait for one another

KEY INSIGHT: Paul's structure is deliberate — he grounds his ethical rebuke (vv. 17–22) in the theological weight of what the meal actually is (vv. 23–26) before issuing the warning. The warning is not free-floating; it flows from the identity of the meal.

Section 2 — Author's Intent & Original Audience

Authorship, Date, and Circumstances

Paul wrote 1 Corinthians approximately 53–55 AD from Ephesus. He founded the Corinthian church on his second missionary journey (~50 AD, Acts 18:1–18). The church existed in Corinth — a major commercial hub, the capital of the Roman province of Achaia, known for its cosmopolitan diversity, economic stratification, and notorious moral permissiveness. The letter is in response to both oral reports (the 'Chloe faction,' 1:11) and a written correspondence from the Corinthians (7:1, 'now concerning the matters you wrote about').

Historical & Cultural Background Details

Detail 1: The House Church and Spatial Segregation

There were no purpose-built church buildings in the first century. The Corinthian church met in a wealthy patron's home — most likely Gaius (Romans 16:23), described as 'host to the whole church.' Roman homes of the wealthy were architecturally stratified: the triclinium (formal dining room) held 9–12 reclining guests at most; the atrium or courtyard accommodated additional guests of lower status. This physical arrangement was not neutral — it encoded social hierarchy into the seating. When the church gathered for the Lord's Supper, the spatial realities of the Roman house almost automatically reproduced the patronage system within the gathered assembly.

Detail 2: Greco-Roman Meal Customs and the Deipnon

Greco-Roman dinner customs (the deipnon and symposion) were governed by strict social protocol. Wealthier guests typically arrived early and were served first and better. Pliny the Younger (a near-contemporary of Paul) complained about hosts who served better wine to honored guests while lesser guests received inferior cups — the exact dynamic Paul confronts in Corinth. The Lord's Supper in Corinth was embedded within a larger communal meal (agape feast), and the wealthy were not waiting — they were eating their own private meals (idion deipnon, v. 21) before the working-class members and slaves could arrive. Many laborers and slaves would not finish work until sundown.

Detail 3: Social Shame as Spiritual Violence

Paul's charge is sharpened by the word 'kataischunō' (v. 22) — to humiliate, to put to shame. In the honor-shame culture of the Greco-Roman world, public humiliation at a shared table was not a minor embarrassment; it was a social wound. For slaves and freedpersons who had found genuine equality in the Christian assembly, being served last or left hungry while the wealthy feasted with full cups was an existential contradiction of the gospel. Paul calls it what it is: they are 'despising the church of God' (v. 22).

What Original Hearers Understood That Modern Readers Miss

Modern readers often approach vv. 27–29 as a warning about individual spiritual preparation. But first-century hearers would have heard Paul's warning in an entirely communal register. The word 'body' (sōma) in 'not discerning the body' (v. 29) would have immediately evoked the ecclesial body Paul developed in chapters 10 and 12 — the community of believers. The

Corinthians were not failing to be reverent enough toward the bread; they were failing to see that the hungry, shamed members of the church were the body of Christ. Discerning the body = seeing the poor as Christ's own body.

KEY INSIGHT: The 'unworthy manner' Paul warns about is not personal moral impurity but a specific communal sin — shaming the poor while claiming fellowship at Christ's table. This passage is as much about economic justice as it is about sacramental reverence.

Section 3 — Key Word Studies (Greek)

Five Greek terms define the theological architecture of this passage. Understanding them reshapes both interpretation and application.

κυριακὸν δεῖπνον (Kuriakon deipnon) G2960 + G1173

Definition: Meal belonging to the Lord; the Lord's own Supper. The adjective kuriakon (from kurios, 'lord/master') specifies sacred ownership — this is not a private dinner but a meal consecrated to Christ.

Source: Strong's G2960 (kuriakos), G1173 (deipnon). The only other NT use of kuriakos: 'the Lord's Day' (Rev 1:10).

Cross-references: Rev 1:10 (Lord's Day); 1 Cor 10:21 ('the Lord's table'); Luke 14:24 (deipnon as banquet)

Preaching depth: The meal's name is its first sermon. It is the Lord's — not the host's, not the wealthy patrons', not the church's. When Corinthians treat it as their own social occasion, they violate the possessive right embedded in the name itself. Preach the ownership: whose table is this?

ἀναξίως (Anaxiōs) G371

Definition: Unworthily; in a manner that is unbecoming or unfitting. An adverb, not an adjective. The alpha privative negates axios ('of equal weight; worthy'), meaning 'not giving proper weight to what is being done.'

Source: Strong's G371. Hapax legomenon in the NT (appears only here, v. 27). Related adjective anaxios occurs at 1 Cor 6:2.

Cross-references: 1 Cor 6:2 (related adjective); Luke 20:35 (axios, 'worthy'); Phil 1:27 (axios — 'conduct yourselves in a manner worthy')

Preaching depth: This word is the most misread term in the passage. Paul does not say, 'Worthy people may eat; unworthy people must abstain.' He says the manner of participation must honor what the meal is. The warning targets behavior (ignoring the poor, eating selfishly) not personal spiritual status. Recovering this prevents both morbid self-exclusion and casual indifference.

διακρίνω (Diakrinō) G1252

Definition: To distinguish, discern, judge, make a distinction. Compound: dia ('through') + krinō ('to judge'). Range includes: to evaluate carefully, to discriminate, to separate out, to examine.

Source: Strong's G1252. BDAG: 'to make a distinction, differentiate; to evaluate by distinguishing.' Used 19x in NT with varying shades.

Cross-references: 1 Cor 12:10 (discerning of spirits); Rom 14:23 (doubting/hesitating); Matt 16:3 (discerning weather signs); 1 Cor 11:31 (judging ourselves)

Preaching depth: The same verb governs both v. 29 ('not discerning the body') and v. 31 ('if we judged ourselves'). This creates a hinge: the solution to failing to discern the body (others) is to properly discern ourselves. The Corinthians were making the wrong distinctions — rich vs. poor — instead of the right one: recognizing all as one body.

παραδίδωμι (Paradidōmi) G3860

Definition: To hand over, deliver, transmit, entrust. Compound: para ('alongside/from') + didōmi ('to give'). Used for both positive transmission of tradition and negative betrayal.

Source: Strong's G3860. BDAG: 'hand over, give over, deliver, transmit.' Occurs 119x in NT.

Cross-references: 1 Cor 15:3 (passing on the resurrection tradition); Matt 26:15 (Judas 'handing over' Jesus); 2 Thess 2:15 (holding to traditions); Rom 6:17

Preaching depth: Paul uses this word in v. 23 as a chain of transmission: Christ → Paul → Corinthians → future generations. The word creates responsibility: to receive sacred tradition is to become its guardian. The Corinthians have become unfaithful stewards of what they received. Note the irony in v. 23: 'on the night he was betrayed (paradidōmi)' — the same word that describes Judas's betrayal now describes the passing of the Lord's own tradition.

ἀνάμνησις (Anamnēsis) G364

Definition: Remembrance, memorial, active recalling-to-mind. Not passive memory but a dynamic, intentional making-present of a past act. From ana ('again/back') + mnēsis ('memory').

Source: Strong's G364. Appears in NT only in Luke 22:19 and 1 Cor 11:24–25 (twice). In LXX used for the memorial portions of sacrifice (Lev 24:7). BDAG: 'remembrance, reminder, memorial.'

Cross-references: Luke 22:19 (institution at Last Supper); Heb 10:3 (annual reminder of sins); Ps 70:1 LXX (memorial recalling before God)

Preaching depth: Modern scholarship (across Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant lines) recognizes that anamnesis is active, not passive. It does not merely look backward to a completed event; it brings that event into living contact with the present assembly. When the church eats and drinks, it 'proclaims' (v. 26) — an active, corporate, verbal-physical act. The past (cross), present (proclamation), and future (until he comes) are held together in one gesture.

Section 4 — Cross-References & Biblical Connections

Theme A — Passover & Covenant Foundation (OT Background)

Reference	Explanation & Preaching Value
Exodus 12:1–14	The original Passover: blood on doorposts, judgment passing over. Jesus institutes the Supper at Passover — the meal signals both deliverance and coming judgment. Preaching value: Help congregants see that communion is the new Passover. Christ is the lamb.
Exodus 24:8	Moses seals the Sinai covenant: 'Behold the blood of the covenant.' Jesus echoes this at the Last Supper ('new covenant in my blood'). The meal is covenant ratification — binding God and his people in sacred commitment.
Jeremiah 31:31–34	God promises a new covenant written on hearts, not stone. Jesus explicitly cites this at the institution (Luke 22:20). Preaching value: The Lord's Supper announces that the new covenant has arrived — God's law internalized, sins forgiven.
Deut 16:1–8	Passover observance in the Promised Land — communal, celebratory, inclusive. The poor are not excluded. Connect to Paul's rebuke: a Passover that excludes the poor inverts its own meaning.

Theme B — Institution Narratives (Gospel Parallels)

Reference	Explanation & Preaching Value
Luke 22:14–20	The fullest Gospel account. Jesus says 'I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.' Eschatological urgency and relational intimacy. Preaching value: The Supper is an act of deep longing — Christ wanting to share this moment with his people.
Matthew 26:26–29	Institution with the eschatological note: 'I will not drink from this fruit of the vine until that day when I drink it new with you in my Father's kingdom.' The Supper is forward-pointing — a promissory meal.
Mark 14:22–26	Institution followed by a hymn and departure to Gethsemane. The meal's shadow is Gethsemane — immediately after comes the betrayal, arrest, and cross. Preaching value: The Supper leads directly to the cross; it is not a celebration apart from suffering.

Theme C — Body of Christ & Unity

Reference	Explanation & Preaching Value
1 Cor 10:16–17	The cup of blessing and the loaf make participants one body: 'Because there is one loaf, we who are many are one body, for we all share the one loaf.' Paul's argument in ch. 11 flows directly from ch. 10 — the theological unity proclaimed in 10:17 is being actively violated in 11:18–22.
1 Cor 12:12–27	The body metaphor extended: 'If one part suffers, every part suffers with it.' The hungry member's suffering is the body's suffering. The wealthy Corinthians eating while others go hungry is the body eating while ignoring its own hunger.

Ephesians 4:1–6	One body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism. The indicative of unity precedes the imperative of peace. The Supper is the visible enactment of this unity.
Galatians 3:28	'Neither Jew nor Gentile, slave nor free, male nor female — all one in Christ Jesus.' The Supper is the concrete, bodily expression of this declaration. Divisions at the table deny it.

Theme D — Divine Discipline vs. Condemnation

Reference	Explanation & Preaching Value
Hebrews 12:5–11	God disciplines those he loves — discipline is evidence of sonship, not rejection. 'No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness.' Directly parallels Paul's distinction between krima (v. 29–31) and katakrima (v. 32).
1 Peter 4:17	'For it is time for judgment to begin with God's household.' Temporal judgment within the church is not condemnation but refinement. The Corinthians' sickness and death (v. 30) is the household's purification.
1 Cor 5:5	Paul's earlier use of handing someone over to Satan 'for the destruction of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved on the day of the Lord.' Temporal judgment serves ultimate salvation — the same logic as 11:32.

Theme E — Economic Equality & Care for the Poor

Reference	Explanation & Preaching Value
James 2:1–9	'Have you not discriminated among yourselves and become judges with evil thoughts?' James confronts the same dynamic: the wealthy get the best seats, the poor are marginalized. 'Listen, my dear brothers and sisters: Has not God chosen those who are poor in the eyes of the world to be rich in faith?'
Acts 2:44–45	The Jerusalem church sold possessions and shared 'to anyone who had need.' The generosity of the early church is the positive counterpart to the Corinthian failure. What the Jerusalem church practiced, the Corinthians abandoned.
2 Cor 8:9	'For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you through his poverty might become rich.' Christ's self-impoverishment is the model the Corinthians refuse to follow at the table.

Section 5 — Historical & Modern Commentary

5A — Historical Commentary Voices

John Chrysostom (c. 347–407 AD)

Chrysostom's Homily 27 on 1 Corinthians is one of the most sustained patristic engagements with this passage. He identifies the core offense: the wealthy have privatized a meal that belongs to the whole body.

> "What can be more contrary to the nature of things than for men to feast luxuriously in the church, while others are pining with hunger? It was not to insult the poor, but to show contempt for Christ, that they did these things."
>
> **— John Chrysostom, Homily 27 on 1 Corinthians**

Chrysostom draws a devastating comparison: 'in that supper too had them all reclining at meat together: yet surely not so great was the distance between the Teacher and the disciples as between the rich and the poor among you.' His argument is Christological — the Lord's table must mirror the Lord's character. Christ reclined with his disciples as equals; the Corinthians reproduced class hierarchy at the very table meant to abolish it.

On the physical consequences (v. 30): Chrysostom reads these as genuine divine discipline, not metaphor — 'He permitted these things to remind them of their error, and lead them to self-correction.' He frames sickness and death as merciful warnings, not vindictive punishment.

John Calvin (1509–1564)

Calvin's Commentary on 1 Corinthians focuses this passage on the soteriology of worthy reception. He insists the warning is not about moral perfection but right orientation toward Christ.

> "We must not account it a common or ordinary supper, but must know that it has been appointed by the Lord for the purpose of spiritual nourishment. The man who does not apply his mind to examine himself, and does not approach with reverence and faith, eats and drinks judgment to himself."
>
> **— John Calvin, Commentary on First Corinthians**

Calvin on 'discerning the body' (v. 29): He distinguishes between the physical elements and the spiritual reality they signify. Failure to discern is failure to recognize that the bread signifies Christ's body given for sinners — and thus to treat the meal as nothing more than a common supper. For Calvin, worthy reception requires two things: genuine recognition of one's own unworthiness (leading to faith in Christ) and recognition of what is being set before us.

Calvin also addresses the communal dimension, noting that the Corinthians 'brought reproach upon the Lord's Supper by their disorderly and profane manner of observing it,' particularly through class contempt.

Augustine of Hippo (354–430 AD)

Augustine's eucharistic theology is crystallized in his famous sermon on 1 Corinthians 10:17, often applied to this passage:

> "O sacrament of devotion! O sign of unity! O bond of charity! Whoever wishes to live has here a place to live in, has here the very thing to live by. Let him come, let him believe, let him be embodied, that he may be made alive."
>
> **— Augustine, Tractate 26 on John's Gospel (applied to Eucharistic unity)**

Augustine applies his theology of the mystical body directly to the Corinthian situation: the Eucharist is simultaneously a sign of what the church is (one body) and a means of becoming what it proclaims. When the Corinthians divide at the table, they contradict the sacrament's inner logic. Their 'eating' is not truly the Lord's Supper because the bond of charity is severed. Augustine's famous phrase captures Paul's logic: 'They who fail to keep the bond of peace receive not a sacrament that benefits them, but an indictment that condemns them.'

Matthew Henry (1662–1714)

> "If ever there was a place or an occasion where social distinctions should have been set aside and Christian equality recognized, it was at this feast of brotherly love and commemoration of the common redemption... They had changed it from a holy supper into a common feast."
>
> **— Matthew Henry, Commentary on 1 Corinthians 11**

Henry's pastoral instinct is sharp: he observes that if the ordinances of Christ 'do not improve us, they will be apt to make us worse, and if the use of them does not mend, it will harden.' The Lord's Supper properly observed is a means of grace; improperly observed, it intensifies judgment. Henry also emphasizes Paul's restoration-oriented intent: the apostle wants the Corinthians to reform their practice so that the meal can once again be what it was meant to be.

5B — Modern Commentary Voices

Gordon Fee (The First Epistle to the Corinthians, NICNT)

Fee's landmark commentary brought socio-historical analysis to this passage with rigor. He argues the divisions were fundamentally class-based, not theological or factional in the sense of chapters 1–4.

> "The problem is not some kind of 'taking of the Supper' apart from others; it is that the meal reflects the social distinctions of the broader culture, thus contradicting the very nature of the meal itself. The wealthy patron who opened his home had the right — in terms of the culture — to serve whom and what he wished. Paul simply says: not at this table."
>
> **— Gordon Fee, The First Epistle to the Corinthians (NICNT), on vv. 17–22**

On 'discerning the body' (v. 29): Fee argues decisively for the ecclesial reading — 'the body' is the church, not the eucharistic elements. 'The whole context is about their failure to be the church when they come together... the unworthy manner consists of the divisions themselves.' This is the majority position among modern NT scholars.

Fee also addresses the physical consequences (v. 30) as genuine: 'The divine disciplines them with physical illnesses... as a warning to the church.' He connects this to 1 Cor 5:5 — temporal judgment serving ultimate salvation.

N.T. Wright (Paul for Everyone: 1 Corinthians)

Wright situates the passage within his new creation theology. For Wright, the church's gathered life is a proleptic sign of the renewed world — and division at the table contradicts this witness.

> "Every time you eat this bread and drink this cup, you are announcing the Lord's death until he comes. It is a public proclamation, a shout to the world and to the principalities and powers that Jesus is Lord and that his death — not Caesar's power, not the power of wealth — defines reality."
>
> **— N.T. Wright, Paul for Everyone: 1 Corinthians**

Wright emphasizes the eschatological framing of v. 26 ('until he comes') as determinative. The Supper is not merely a memorial of the past but a forward-facing act of allegiance — pledging loyalty to a returning King. When the wealthy Corinthians replicate Roman patronage hierarchies at the table, they are pledging loyalty to Caesar's world order rather than Christ's.

Richard Hays (First Corinthians, Interpretation Series)

Hays presses the ethical center of the passage with characteristic intensity. He insists that Paul's argument has a specific target: the 'pneumatics' (the spiritually elite) who were treating the Lord's Supper as a display of status.

> "The issue at stake is not merely a question of manners or etiquette but a theological matter of the first order: the failure to recognize the poor as members of the body of Christ is a failure to discern the Lord's body. It is a denial of what the gospel proclaims."
>
> **— Richard Hays, First Corinthians (Interpretation), p. 200**

Hays also draws attention to the remarkable theological move Paul makes in vv. 23–26: in the midst of a scolding letter about social chaos, Paul rehearses the words of institution with careful solemnity. The effect is jarring and intentional — Paul holds the ideal and the failure in sharp contrast to show the Corinthians how far they have fallen.

Ben Witherington III (Conflict and Community in Corinth)

Witherington's socio-rhetorical analysis illuminates the cultural machinery driving the problem. He notes that the Roman 'convivium' (dinner party) reinforced the patron-client relationship through differential food and wine — better food and drink for honored guests, lesser portions for others.

> "What was happening in Corinth was not an anomaly but a culturally normal expression of Roman social life — brought wholesale into the church assembly. Paul's genius is to show that the Christian meal has its own social logic, rooted in Christ's self-giving, that fundamentally subverts the Roman patronage system."
>
> **— Ben Witherington III, Conflict and Community in Corinth**

Major scholarly debates on this passage: (1) Does 'the body' in v. 29 mean the eucharistic bread or the ecclesial community? Modern consensus: ecclesial, though the ambiguity may be intentional. (2) Is v. 30 ('some have fallen asleep') literal death or metaphorical? Majority: literal. (3) Was this a 'full meal' or only symbolic elements? Clearly a full meal, given v. 21 ('one is hungry, another drunk').

Systematic theology connections: Ecclesiology (the church as body), Sacramentology (nature and function of the Lord's Supper), Soteriology (the difference between discipline and condemnation), Eschatology ('until he comes').

CATEGORY 2 — THEOLOGICAL IMPLICATIONS: What the Text Means

Section 6 — Theological Themes & Synthesis

Theme 1 — The Lord's Supper as Proclamation: Memorial, Presence, and Eschatology

The word anamnēsis ('remembrance,' vv. 24–25) carries more weight than modern ears assume. In the context of Jewish Passover, 'remembrance' is not passive recollection but active re-presentation — the Passover seder was designed to make the Exodus existentially present to each new generation ('as if you yourself came out of Egypt'). When Jesus commands 'do this in remembrance of me,' he is not asking for nostalgia; he is instituting a practice that makes his redemptive act present to the gathered community.

Verse 26 adds the eschatological dimension: 'you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.' The Supper is temporally triangulated — it looks back (the cross), declares the present (the Lord reigns), and anticipates the future (the parousia). This creates an inherent urgency: every celebration is a countdown to the final meal at the wedding feast of the Lamb (Rev 19:9).

The theological tension: how do we affirm the real significance of the Supper without either (a) reducing it to bare symbol or (b) making it a repetition of the once-for-all sacrifice of Christ? Paul's answer seems to lie in the category of 'proclamation' (katangellō, v. 26) — a public, verbal-bodily act that announces and applies the saving significance of Christ's death.

MOST IMPORTANT INSIGHT: The Supper is not primarily what we do for God (an offering) or even what we remember about God (nostalgia) — it is what God does through us as we eat together: a living proclamation of the cross to the watching world, to the powers, and to ourselves.

Theme 2 — The Inseparability of Sacrament and Ethics

The most theologically profound move in the passage is Paul's refusal to separate sacramental participation from communal ethics. The Corinthians thought they could celebrate Christ's body in the bread while treating Christ's body (the poor members of the church) with contempt. Paul dismantles this: there is only one body of Christ, and how you treat the gathered poor is how you treat Christ.

This connects to the deepest logic of the incarnation: God took on a body, so bodies matter. The bread represents a body that was broken for others — the Supper is inherently self-giving in its structure. To eat it selfishly is not merely rude; it is a theological contradiction. Calvin saw this: the one who 'pervert[s] the pure and right use of the sacrament' is eating judgment precisely because the sacrament announces what they are refusing to embody.

Historical connection: this tension runs from Corinth through Augustine's 'bond of charity' through the Reformation debates to modern liberation theologians like Gustavo Gutiérrez, who argued that authentic Eucharist requires commitment to the poor. The thread is unbroken: the table has always asked what we do with the hungry.

MOST IMPORTANT INSIGHT: You cannot 'discern the body' (v. 29) if you only look down at the bread. You must also look across the table at the person next to you.

Theme 3 — Discipline vs. Condemnation: The Soteriological Distinction

Paul's vocabulary in vv. 29–32 is carefully differentiated. The Greek krima (v. 29, 34) is a judicial decision — a verdict that may be corrective. The Greek katakrima (v. 32) is final, condemning judgment. Paul's devastating pastoral assurance is in v. 32: 'When we are judged by the Lord, we are being disciplined so that we will not be finally condemned with the world.'

The sickness and deaths (v. 30) are therefore not evidence of God's rejection but of God's fatherly discipline (Hebrews 12:5–11). The temporal judgment protects the Corinthians from eternal judgment. This is simultaneously a terrifying warning and a profound pastoral comfort: God takes the church's conduct seriously enough to discipline it, but the discipline is rehabilitative, not punitive in the final sense.

The theological tension: How do we preach temporal judgment (sickness and death as divine discipline) in a pastoral context without turning it into a cruel weapon against the suffering? Answer: the discipline is always diagnostic ('so that we will not be condemned,' v. 32), never random or vindictive, and always opens toward self-examination and reform (v. 28, 31).

MOST IMPORTANT INSIGHT: The difference between discipline and condemnation is the difference between a father and a judge. God disciplines his children; he condemns the world. 1 Corinthians 11:32 is a promise embedded in a warning.

Theme 4 — The New Covenant and the Politics of the Table

'This cup is the new covenant in my blood' (v. 25) — Paul quotes Jesus citing Jeremiah 31:31–34. The new covenant is written on hearts, not stone; it is internalized, egalitarian, and inclusive ('from the least to the greatest'). The new covenant's table is therefore a political act: it declares that the social hierarchies of the old age have been superseded.

In Corinth, the table meal was the most socially charged ritual in Greco-Roman life — it displayed and reinforced patronage. Paul's reframing: this table follows different rules. Its logic is not Roman patronage but Christ's self-giving. The host did not keep the best wine for honored guests; the host broke himself open and poured himself out for all. To eat at this table is to pledge allegiance to that logic.

Ecumenical and social implications: If the Supper is the public sign of the new covenant, then every act of exclusion at the table — whether social, racial, denominational, or economic — is a contradiction of the covenant itself. This does not flatten all distinctions or eliminate church discipline, but it raises the bar: whom Christ died for, the table should welcome.

Section 7 — The Big Idea & Preaching Angle

Option 1 — The Table Tells the Truth

Big Idea: The Lord's Table is not just a ritual — it is a mirror. How we eat together reveals whether we actually believe the gospel we proclaim.

Entry point: Most people think of communion as a private, spiritual moment between them and God. Paul insists it is irreducibly communal.

Tension created: If the table is a mirror, what does your church's table reveal? Do the poor and rich eat together? Do the margins of your congregation feel honored or overlooked?

Transformation invited: Come to the table as if Christ himself seated you next to the person you'd least choose — because he did.

Option 2 — You Cannot Eat the Body While Ignoring the Body

Big Idea: The bread represents a broken body given for others. You cannot receive it while refusing to extend yourself for others — especially the 'others' sitting beside you.

Entry point: The Corinthians weren't atheists or apostates — they were Christians who thought their spiritual status exempted them from social obligation.

Tension created: Are there ways modern Christians spiritualize their faith to the point where it disconnects from concrete acts of economic and communal solidarity?

Transformation invited: This week, identify one concrete action that makes your love for the body tangible — not just at the table, but in the world.

Option 3 (RECOMMENDED) — Whose Table Is This, Really?

Big Idea: Every time we come to the Lord's Table, we are confronted with a question: Is this table ours or his? And if it's his, it belongs to everyone he died for.

Entry point: The Greek phrase kuriakon deipnon — the Lord's Supper — begins with ownership. Before Paul says anything else, he asks: whose meal is this?

Tension created: If it's the Lord's table, then the Lord gets to set the guest list, the seating arrangements, and the menu. We don't get to recreate our social hierarchies at his table.

Transformation invited: Surrender the table. Come not as a host or a patron, but as a guest — alongside every other guest the Lord has invited.

RECOMMENDED ANGLE: Option 3 — 'Whose Table Is This, Really?' — because it enters through the text's own opening logic (the name 'Lord's Supper'), honors both the sacramental and ethical dimensions, and creates a personal challenge without becoming a guilt-laden lecture.

Section 8 — Sermon Hook & Opening Options

Option A — The One-Liner / Quote

> "The Eucharist is the sacrament of charity, the sign of unity, the bond of love."
>
> **— Augustine of Hippo, Tractates on John**

How to use it: Open by reading this quote slowly. Then ask: 'If that's what the Lord's Table is — if it's the sacrament of charity, the bond of love — what does it look like when we get it wrong? What does it cost us? And what does Paul say we've been doing wrong for 2,000 years?'

Option B — Cultural Reference

Reference: The 2019 film Parasite (Bong Joon-ho) depicts a wealthy family and a poor family whose lives become intertwined — culminating in a catastrophe at a dinner party. The film's central image: wealth and poverty sharing the same physical space without ever truly seeing each other, until the suppressed rage erupts.

Connection: The Corinthian church was its own version of Parasite. The wealthy patrons and poor laborers were in the same room, eating at the same 'table' — and the wealthy genuinely believed nothing was wrong. Paul tears back the curtain: something is very wrong. And the consequences will be real.

Transition language: 'There's a film that captures exactly the world Paul was writing to — a world where wealth and poverty share a table, and the wealthy are the last to notice the damage they're causing. Let me show you what that looks like in the church at Corinth.'

Option C — The Shocking Statistic / Counterintuitive Fact

Fact: Research by sociologists of religion shows that most American congregations are less economically diverse than the neighborhoods surrounding them. Churches tend to sort by income even faster than residential neighborhoods. (Source: (unverified) — verify against recent Pew Research or sociology of religion studies before using.)

How to use it: 'Paul was addressing a problem 2,000 years ago that we have not solved. In fact, by some measures, the church today is more economically segregated than the culture around it. What would happen if the Lord's Supper confronted us with that — if every time we ate that bread, we had to ask: who is at this table, and who isn't?'

CATEGORY 3 — PRACTICAL APPLICATION: How We Live This Out

Section 9 — Text-Driven Sermon Outline

Working Title: Whose Table Is This, Really?

Big Idea: The Lord's Table is not a backdrop for our social habits — it is the place where Christ's lordship most concretely challenges how we treat each other.

INTRODUCTION — The Name Changes Everything (vv. 17–20)

- Open with the Greek name: kuriakon deipnon — 'the Lord's Supper.' It belongs to the Lord. Before Paul says anything else, the name is the sermon.
- What it does to the listener: Shifts ownership. This is not 'our tradition' or 'our service' — it is his table.
- Application thread: What does it mean to come as a guest rather than a host? What are the assumptions we bring to the table that Christ wants to rearrange?

Movement 1 — The Problem: A Meal That Does More Harm Than Good (vv. 17–22)

- What it says: Paul confronts a church where the rich eat first, the poor go hungry, and the gathering reproduces the worst of Roman social hierarchy inside the body of Christ.
- What it does: Creates productive discomfort. The congregation recognizes the human tendency to replicate status games even in sacred spaces.
- Application thread: Where are the subtle social hierarchies in your church? Who eats first? Who feels seen? Who feels humiliated? Name it honestly.

Movement 2 — The Foundation: What This Meal Actually Is (vv. 23–26)

- What it says: Paul interrupts his rebuke to recite the words of institution with careful, almost liturgical solemnity. The contrast with the Corinthians' behavior is jarring.
- What it does: Reorients. The congregation hears the familiar words of institution in the context of failure, which makes them land with new weight.
- Application thread: Every time you eat this bread, you are announcing something. What does your manner of participation announce?

Key preaching moment: Linger on v. 26 — 'you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.' This is not private. It is public proclamation. The table is an act of speech.

Movement 3 — The Warning: Eating Judgment (vv. 27–32)

- What it says: Unworthy manner = not discerning the body. The warning is not about personal sinfulness but about failing to see the gathered community as Christ's own body.

- What it does: Raises the stakes — without inducing paralyzing guilt. This is serious, but the word anaxiōs (v. 27) is an adverb describing manner, not an adjective describing worth.
- Application thread: Self-examination (v. 28) is not a purity test. It is a question: Am I participating in a way that honors Christ and recognizes my brothers and sisters?

Crucial distinction: krima (v. 29) vs. katakrima (v. 32). Discipline is not condemnation. The warning is fatherly, not vindictive.

Preach v. 32 as a promise: 'so that we will not be finally condemned with the world.' The discipline is mercy.

Movement 4 — The Correction: Wait for One Another (vv. 33–34)

- What it says: Paul's solution is almost shockingly practical — slow down and wait for each other.
- What it does: Grounds the theology. The big theological argument lands in the simplest possible instruction: see the other person, wait for them, eat together.
- Application thread: What would it look like to 'wait for each other' in your community this week — not just at the table, but in how you see and honor those on the margins of your church?

CLOSING / LANDING MOMENT

Land on the image of Christ at his own table — not the one who eats first, not the one who serves himself best, but the one who takes the bread, gives thanks, breaks it, and says 'this is for you.' Every time we eat together, we are enacting either his logic or the world's logic. The question is simple: whose table is this, really?

Invitation: If you have been keeping someone out — from your circle, from your table, from your full regard — this meal is Christ's invitation to let that go. Come as a guest. Bring them as guests. Eat together.

Section 10 — Illustration Bank

ILLUSTRATION 1 — Historical: The Divided Table (Civil Rights Era)

In the 1960s American South, communion in segregated churches was a flashpoint. Some congregations maintained separate communion tables, separate cups, or separate services for Black and white members — while preaching from the same Bible about the one body of Christ. When the civil rights movement pressed for integration, one of the first contested spaces was the communion rail. Several accounts describe white deacons blocking Black worshippers from kneeling at the rail. The irony was not lost on the Black church theologians of the era: 'They say this is Christ's table, and then they tell Christ who can come.' Paul's words to the Corinthians were being replayed, almost verse by verse, in churches claiming to honor them. Best landing spot: Movement 1 (the problem of social hierarchy in the church).

ILLUSTRATION 2 — Analogy: The Doctor Who Examines in Isolation

Imagine a doctor who examines each organ of a patient independently — heart, lungs, kidneys — and pronounces each one 'fine.' But the patient collapses anyway, because the organs weren't communicating with each other. The problem wasn't any single organ; it was the failure of the body to function as a whole. This is what the Corinthians were doing at communion. They were examining the bread (is this sacred?), examining their own hearts (am I worthy?), but not examining the body — the gathered community. Paul's 'discerning the body' is a diagnosis of systemic failure, not individual sin. Best landing spot: Movement 3 (discerning the body).

ILLUSTRATION 3 — Contemporary: The Executive at the Rail

A businesswoman known for ruthlessness in commercial real estate attended an evening communion service — her first in years — almost by accident. As she knelt at the rail, a man from a transitional housing program knelt beside her. She had passed him on the street outside the church dozens of times without really seeing him. Something about kneeling at the same level, reaching for the same cup, cracked something in her. Not a conversion — she was already a Christian. But a recognition: this man's body mattered as much as hers. Christ had given himself for both of them equally. She became a primary supporter of that church's housing ministry. She said later: 'I didn't change at an altar call. I changed at a communion rail, next to someone I had been trained to look past.' Best landing spot: Closing / Invitation.

ILLUSTRATION 4 — Everyday Life: What It Means to Share a Table

In most cultures across history, to eat with someone is to declare peace. Ancient Near Eastern covenant rituals involved shared meals. Genesis 31 records Jacob and Laban eating together to seal a covenant. The prodigal son's return is celebrated with a feast. The shepherd who finds the lost sheep throws a party. Table fellowship in the ancient world was not casual — it was covenantal. You did not share bread with your enemy. So when Paul says the Corinthians are 'eating together' while despising each other, he is pointing out a contradiction that any first-century person would immediately recognize: if you're willing to

eat with someone, you're pledging something. The question is whether you mean it. Best landing spot: Introduction or Movement 1.

ILLUSTRATION 5 — Metaphor: The Proclamation That Speaks Without Words

When a congregation gathers around a table where the wealthy and poor, the prominent and the marginalized, eat together as equals — that is a sermon. It does not need a preacher. The table preaches. Paul says in v. 26: 'you proclaim the Lord's death whenever you eat this bread.' The verb is katangellō — to announce publicly, to declare. The Supper is speech. The Corinthians' table was speaking the wrong message: rank matters, wealth wins, some people are more important than others. Paul wants the table to proclaim a different truth: Christ died for all equally, and his table reflects that. Best landing spot: Movement 2 (the foundation — what this meal actually is).

Section 11 — Practical Application & Life Change

These 'you' statements are designed for use in the sermon's application section. They cross the full breadth of life contexts.

Faith & Spiritual Life

- You can approach communion with reverence for the bread and contempt for the person next to you — and Paul says that's not communion at all. Examine which direction your eyes are actually pointed when you take the cup.
- Self-examination before communion (v. 28) is not a guilt audit. It is a relational check: Am I participating as part of a body, or as a private individual performing a ritual?

Relationships & Community

You cannot truly share the Lord's Table with someone you are actively refusing to see. The Table is Christ's invitation to reconcile what your daily life keeps divided.

- Is there someone in your congregation you have subtly ranked below yourself — in your attention, your regard, your willingness to share a meal with them? The Table confronts that.
- Waiting for each other (v. 33) is not a liturgical instruction — it is a way of life. It means slowing down enough to notice who hasn't arrived yet, who is on the margins, who is still outside.

Work & Calling

- If you hold authority or wealth, the Table asks: Do your professional instincts follow you into the church? Do you unconsciously seek the best seat, the most important conversation, the recognition due your status? The Lord's Table is the great equalizer — not because it pretends status doesn't exist, but because it insists Christ died for everyone here equally.

Everyday Habits

Practice 'table theology' in ordinary meals this week: invite someone you wouldn't normally eat with. Let the logic of the Lord's Table extend beyond Sunday.

- Consider how your church's actual shared meals — potlucks, coffees, church dinners — reflect (or contradict) the values of the Lord's Supper. Is there genuine mixing of economic backgrounds? Are the poor honored or invisible?

Two Next-Step Prompts for the Sermon Close

Next Step 1: Before you take communion this week, ask yourself: Is there someone in this congregation I have been ranking — in my regard, my friendship, my attention? Name them. Come to the table with that name in mind.

Next Step 2: This week, invite one person from a different economic background than yours to share a meal. It doesn't need to be profound. Just eat together. Let the table teach you what the sacrament is pointing toward.

Section 12 — Hard Questions & Potential Objections

Question 1 (Skeptic): 'Isn't Paul just policing table manners? This seems like a lot of theology for a dinner etiquette dispute.'

Honest response: On the surface, yes — Paul is correcting how people eat together. But the theological stakes are enormous because, for Paul, how the community eats together is a public proclamation about what they believe. If the church is the 'body of Christ,' then the body's most visible act of unity — the shared meal — becomes the most credible or most hypocritical witness to the gospel. A church that reproduces Roman class hierarchy at the Lord's Table is testifying that Caesar's world order still governs them. Etiquette becomes eschatology.

Sermon usage: Use this early, to head off the dismissal that the passage is merely procedural.

Question 2 (Grieving / Suffering): 'My child died at a young age. Does Paul's logic mean they were being punished for unworthy communion? How do I read verse 30?'

Honest response: This is one of the genuinely difficult texts in Paul's letters. Paul attributes physical illness and death in the Corinthian community to divine discipline for their specific, identified sin of social contempt at the table. He does not offer a universal principle that all sickness or death signals divine punishment. Paul himself experienced illness (Galatians 4:13–14), and Jesus explicitly rejects the equation of suffering with sin (John 9:3). The passage must be read in its specific context: a community engaged in a specific, ongoing, identified sin. Pastoral response to the grieving: God's discipline in this passage is a response to communal injustice, not individual spiritual failure. Your child's death is not a verdict.

Sermon usage: Address this briefly in Movement 3, especially if your congregation has recently experienced loss.

Question 3 (Theologically Curious): 'Does this passage support real presence (Catholic/Lutheran) or just symbolic remembrance (Baptist/Reformed)?'

Honest response: Paul does not resolve the question systematically. What he does insist on: (a) the meal is not 'just a meal' — it carries sacred significance; (b) the manner of participation has real spiritual consequences; (c) 'discerning the body' is essential. Most scholars read this as pointing toward more than bare symbolism — the word anamnēsis implies active, participatory recollection that makes the past event present in some real sense. But Paul's concern is not metaphysical (what happens to the bread?) but ethical (what happens to the body — the church?). The denominations have fought over the wrong question. Paul's question is: Are you eating in a way that honors the body of Christ — both the eucharistic and the ecclesial?

Sermon usage: Footnote this for the theologically curious; don't make it the sermon's center.

Question 4 (Socially Conscious): 'Does this passage demand economic redistribution? Is this a socialism proof-text?'

Honest response: Paul does not call for the abolition of private property or a mandated economic structure. His corrective is practical and communal: wait for each other, share the meal together, don't humiliate the poor. But the logic runs deeper than table manners. If the Lord's Table makes all participants equal as recipients of Christ's grace, the community's economic practices should increasingly reflect that equality — not by legal compulsion, but by the transformation of desire. The Jerusalem church's voluntary sharing (Acts 2:44–45) is the

positive model. Paul's concern is not a political program but a community whose love for one another is tangible and material, not merely sentimental.

Question 5 (Ecclesiastical): 'How unworthy is too unworthy? When should someone be excluded from communion?'

Honest response: Paul does not answer this precisely. What he says is: (a) self-examination is each individual's responsibility (v. 28); (b) the manner of participation is what matters; (c) the judgment for unworthy participation is self-incurred (v. 29 — 'on themselves'). The passage does not give church leaders a license to exclude based on their assessment of others' worthiness. The Supper is always a place of self-reckoning before Christ, not a place where the gathered perform purity assessments on each other. Church discipline (1 Cor 5) is a separate question. Here, Paul's corrective is communal reform, not individual exclusion.

Section 13 — Group Discussion & Reflection Questions

Designed for a general adult small group. No seminary vocabulary required. 6–8 questions that move from observation to transformation.

Icebreaker

- Tell about a meal — family dinner, celebration, or ordinary Tuesday — that felt genuinely communal and meaningful. What made it that way?

Observation (What does the text say?)

- Read vv. 17–22 aloud. What specific behaviors is Paul upset about? Try to describe them in your own words as if explaining them to someone who has never heard of this passage.
- What does Paul say the Corinthians are doing to 'those who have nothing' (v. 22)? Why does he call that 'despising the church of God'?

Interpretation (What does the text mean?)

- Paul says in v. 26 that 'whenever you eat this bread and drink this cup, you proclaim the Lord's death.' What do you think it means that eating together is a form of proclamation? What message does a church's table send?
- Verse 29 warns about 'not discerning the body.' The passage could mean either the bread (Christ's physical body) or the church (the body of believers). Which reading do you find more compelling, given the context? What difference does it make for how you approach communion?

Application (What does the text ask of me?)

- Paul tells the Corinthians to 'wait for each other' (v. 33). That's surprisingly practical. What would it look like, concretely, for your church community to 'wait for each other' — not just at communion, but in how you live together week to week?
- Is there someone in your community (church, neighborhood, workplace) who feels invisible or ranked below others — including by you? How might the logic of the Lord's Table speak to that?

Reflection (Personal transformation)

- Paul says in v. 28 to 'examine yourself' before eating. What does that kind of examination look like for you, practically? What questions would you ask yourself?

Section 14 — Past Sermon Cross-References

Note: A thorough search of the Sermon Prep workspace was conducted. No past sermon archive (RTF files or any other sermon outlines) was found in the selected folder at this time. The Sermon Prep folder appears to be empty or the archive has not yet been added to this workspace.

14A — Direct Hits (Same Passage or Book)

No previous sermons found referencing 1 Corinthians 11 or the Lord's Supper directly. Archive search returned no results.

14B — Thematic Connections

No archive data available from which to identify thematic matches. Once sermon outlines are added to the Sermon Prep folder, a search for the following themes would be productive: Unity / Division, Communion / Lord's Supper, The Body of Christ, Economic Justice / Caring for the Poor, Self-Examination, Divine Discipline vs. Condemnation, New Covenant.

14C — Preacher's Notes for This Message

Because no archive is available, the following notes are based on the passage itself rather than prior preaching history: 1 Corinthians 11:17-34 is among the most practically and theologically rich passages in Paul's writings, and it touches themes — table fellowship, economic equality, ecclesial unity, sacramental participation — that will almost certainly connect to prior series on community, the church, or the Christian life. Once your archive is loaded into this workspace, re-running the archive search would be valuable to map: (a) whether you have preached through 1 Corinthians before; (b) any prior messages on the Lord's Supper or communion theology; (c) any series on church community, body life, or care for the poor that this passage could build on or depart from. This passage works well as a standalone communion meditation, as part of a 1 Corinthians series, or as the anchor of a series on what it means to be the church.